The World of Men

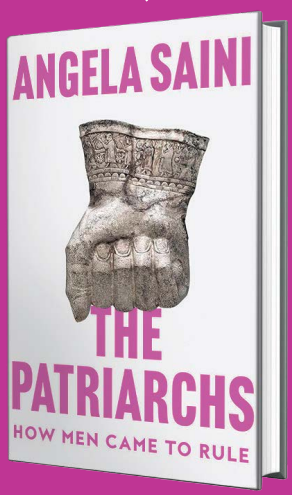
IN *THE PATRIARCHS*, **ANGELA SAINI** PARSES THE SOCIAL CONSTRUCT THAT DETERMINES POWER AND ENTITLEMENT IN EVERY CULTURE OF THE WORLD

Angela Saini is an award-winning science journalist. Her earlier books have addressed the flashpoint issues of our times, such as race and gender, and now she turns her telescopic eye onto the patriarchy, the social construct that determines power and entitlement in every culture of the world. Saini's research is staggering—this book has 52 pages of notes and citations—her sources and resources include sociology, anthropology, the human sciences, politics, philosophy, history, museums, monuments, significant buildings and geographies. Her connected essays are studded with references and quotations, all throwing light on the way the patriarchy developed and was sustained across time and space. She argues, however, that how the patriarchy operates depends on who and where we are.

Although this is not news, it bears noticing again that traditional and indigenous societies and cultures have always had more equitable power relations between people, whether through matrilineal systems of inheritance and status (as in Kerala and India's Northeast) or through active, and often leading, roles in the political life of the community (as with many First Nations in North America). As we read Saini's essays, it's hard to ignore the growing conviction that it was the civilising conceits of colonialism and the heady rush of capitalism that cemented the patriarchal systems that dominate the modern world. Saini reminds us that the patriarchy is also maintained by the fact that women have been persuaded to internalise its most fundamental brutalities and see it as 'natural' or even as inevitable. As a result, we support it without being conscious of how our actions and behaviours enable it.

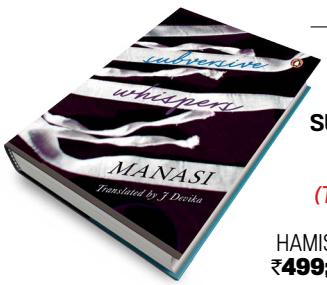
From the long fight for women's right to vote to the demand for gender parity in pay structures, there has always been resistance and pushback. Women have used everything that was available

THE PATRIARCHS
How Men Came to Rule
by Angela Saini
HARPERCOLLINS
₹699; 320 pages



Patriarchy in the Labyrinth

*This collection of veteran Malayalam writer **Manasi**'s short stories serves up raw and honest feminist literature from a past era*



SUBVERSIVE WHISPERS
by Manasi
(Translated by J. Devika)
HAMISH HAMILTON
₹499; 160 pages

Subversive Whispers is a small collection of stories by Manasi, a widely-read and prize-winning writer in Malayalam, rendered acceptably into English. These stories, of the kind usually published in women's journals, represent an earlier feminist literature, more problematic, more stomach-churning. Young readers of those journals especially, back in the day, may have hoped that there was an easier path through the labyrinths of patriarchy (as translator J. Devika puts it). Perhaps it would all work out in the end, they might have thought, hurrying on to the film news and recipe pages. The stories were written to challenge, not to reassure with pat conclusions and comforting outcomes. And certainly not to entertain.

Today, they have a documentary, sometimes medicinal quality. They are an object of study. But they offer us raw honesty, a far cry from the ultra-processed text that is curated and packaged for today's well-heeled feminist book-buyer. Necessarily this collection is uneven in tone, ranging over many years in the writer's career and having been written for varying publications and audiences. In her translator's note, Devika provides cultural and social context and points out the contradictions and dilemmas of the writer as well as the readers who first encountered her work. Commendably, she does not lapse into facile summaries.

In these stories, Manasi reminds us of the niggling realities of an incarcerated woman's life in the middle of the last century, the dry taps, the boiled-over milk, the missed bus, the demands from misogynistic bosses, husbands and sons. And she writes about the other oppressions—the